Before the Sun

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‘Before the Sun’

Here is a detailed guide to Charles Mungoshi’s poem 'Before the Sun’, from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line “translation” of the poem’s meanings and interpretations
- **Writer’s methods**: an exploration of Mungoshi’s poetic choices and potential effects
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of the themes and ideas within Mungoshi’s poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is important to understand what it is about. This section includes:

- An overview of the poem
- A “translation” of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Charles Mungoshi’s intention and message

‘Before the Sun’ overview

Charles Mungoshi’s poem ‘Before the Sun’, celebrates the simple joys of manual labour in a rural environment. Through a depiction of a young boy cutting wood, Mungoshi portrays a close relationship and sense of harmony between humans and nature.

‘Before the Sun’ breakdown

Lines 1-4

> **“Intense blue morning**
> **promising early heat**
> **and later in the afternoon,**
> **heavy rain.”**

begins with an "intense" heat and turns into a tropical rainstorm later in the day

Mungoshi's intentions

- The poem opens by focusing on extreme weather, creating a rich sensory mood, and showing the power of nature
- The speaker shows awareness of the natural world, knowing that heat and water are what crops (and people) need to develop and survive

Lines 5-11

> **"The bright chips**
> **fly from the sharp axe**
> **for some distance through the air,**
> **arc,**
> **and eternities later,**
> **settle down in showers**
> **on the dewy grass."**

Translation

- The poet describes how wood "chips" scatter and form an "arc" in the air as they are chopped with the "axe"
- They take a long time to land ("eternities"), and then they drop on wet "grass"

Mungoshi's intentions

- Mungoshi describes wood chips scattering like rain, a metaphor that connects the wood-cutter boy with his environment: he creates rain-like woodchips
- The speaker's youth is conveyed through the use of "eternities" as, for young people, time can seem longer

Lines 12-15

> **"It is a big log:**
> **but when you are fourteen**
> **big logs**
> **are what you want."**

Translation

- The narrator says that the teenage boy is happy to have a large piece of wood as this will allow him to prove himself

Mungoshi's intentions

- Mungoshi raises the theme of growing up by depicting a teenage boy carrying out physically demanding manual labour, and taking pride in the challenge

> **"The wood gives off
> a sweet nose-cleansing odour
> which (unlike sawdust)
> doesn't make one sneeze."**

Translation

- The narrator describes the smell of the wood: it is a pure smell, unlike "sawdust"

Mungoshi's intentions

- The poet contrasts the natural wood the boy cuts with the man-made, toxic release of sawdust

Lines 20-25

> **"It sends up a thin spiral
> of smoke which later straightens
> and flutes out
> to the distant sky: a signal
> of some sort,
> or a sacrificial prayer."**

Translation

- The poet describes the smoke that rises from the fire the boy has made with the wood he has cut: it creates a "spiral" that becomes tube-shaped ("flutes")
- It looks like a smoke signal, or as if someone has performed a "sacrificial" ritual

Mungoshi's intentions

- Mungoshi once again links the boy's labour to the natural environment
- The smoke in the "distant sky" is connected to spiritual communication which suggests the boy respects and worships nature

Lines 26-27

> **"The wood hisses,
> The sparks fly."**

Translation

- The narrator describes the fire the boy has made, it is loud and fierce ("sparks fly")

Mungoshi's intentions

"sparks"
    - Mungoshi presents nature as a living thing

Lines 28-33

> **"And when the sun**
> **finally shows up**
> **in the East like some**
> **latecomer to a feast**
> **I have got two cobs of maize**
> **ready for it."**

Translation

- Now it is dawn: the sun rises, and because it has missed all the events of the night, it is like a "latecomer" to a "feast" or party
- A first person voice is introduced: the boy says he has corn ready to give the sun

Mungoshi's intentions

- Using personification to make the sun seem like a guest to his "feast", Mungoshi shows a close connection between the boy and nature
- Finally, the speaker's voice is heard, giving the poem a personal, intimate quality

Lines 34-37

> **"I tell the sun to come share**
> **with me the roasted maize**
> **and the sun just winks**
> **like a grown-up."**

Translation

- The speaker asks the sun to join him in eating the corn he has cooked
- But the sun does not answer, it just "winks"; perhaps it glints in the sky
- The speaker says the sun is like an adult, saying little

Mungoshi's intentions

- There is a light-hearted quality to Mungoshi's poem to show the innocence and optimism of the young boy
- Mungoshi conveys how close humans are to nature when they are in solitude:
    - Mungoshi evokes themes of spirituality in his depiction of a boy thanking nature (the rising sun) by offering his corn

Lines 38–46

> **"So I go ahead, taking big**
> **alternate bites:**
> **one for the sun,**
> **one for me.**
> **This one for the sun,**
> **this one for me:**
> **till the cobs**
> **are just two little skeletons**
> **in the sun."**

Translation

- The speaker describes how he shares his corn with the sun, pretending the sun takes a bite of his corn (although it is really him eating it)
- When all the corn has been chewed off the cobs, they are like "skeletons"

Mungoshi's intentions

- The joy and harmony between humans and nature is illustrated by the tender image of a boy pretending the sun is an imaginary friend
- The striking image of the devoured cobs of corn as "little skeletons in the sun" helps Mungoshi convey the boy's innocence:
  - Although as a final line, it leaves a sinister image in the reader's mind, perhaps foreshadowing struggles ahead for the boy and for nature

Examiner Tips and Tricks

The mark scheme for CIE Literature for English Paper 1 asks for an understanding of characters, relationships, situations and themes. Specifically, examiners reward answers that consider the "deeper meanings of the poem". This means you should spend time thinking about, for example, the reason Charles Mungoshi creates an intensely sensual setting in order to examine the relationship between humans and nature.

Writer's methods

This section is organised into: form, structure, and language. The poetry question in the CIE Literature for English exam wants you to consider all three as "writer's methods" that create meaning or convey ideas. So, your answer should consider the poet's choice of form (its shape and the perspective of the speaker), its structure (the rhythm, rhyme,

Examiners require you to **focus** on the **poem's deeper ideas**, and in a sensitive way. To do this you can discuss how the poet's methods reveal their aim or purpose. That is why all the analysis below is arranged by theme and includes Charles Mungoshi's intentions in terms of his choices of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Form

Charles Mungoshi's poem 'Before the Sun' is in an irregular and free flowing form which portrays the spontaneous reflections of a young boy carrying out his daily tasks and feelings, at one with his environment.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Humans and nature	The poem's nine stanzas vary in length: some stanzas are lengthy descriptions, and others are like haikus (such as in "The wood hisses,/The sparks fly") to convey a simple yet profound experience	Mungoshi conveys the calm solitude of a boy in his natural environment through a first person intimate and rambling voice

Structure

Mungoshi's poem is conversational, with no rhyme scheme or regular rhythm. This contributes to the spontaneous, relaxed voice of an innocent speaker who is excited about growing up.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Individual identity	The poem's lack of rhyme, along with fluid, rambling lines, convey the young boy's thoughts as he reflects on the natural elements, his personal challenges, "prayer", and talks to the sun	Mungoshi portrays a teenage boy's innocence and exuberance as he spends time alone cutting wood all night and into a new day

Language

In 'Before the Sun', Mungoshi uses sensory imagery to present the significance of simple moments of solitude in nature.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention

	"Intense", "bright" and "heavy", and simple sensory imagery that brings to life the "sweet" wood that "hisses", the "dewy grass" and "roasted maize"	is rich in smell and texture to emphasise the depth of the experience

Understanding the text

The poetry questions in the CIE Literature for English exam encourage an **informed**, **personal response**, which means that it is not enough just to know the poem, but that you will also need to develop a **sound understanding** of the **poem's themes, main ideas, settings, situations** and **events** to explore the writer's intentions and methods. This section has been divided into two main themes that Charles Mungoshi examines in his poem 'Before the Sun':

- Individual identity
- Humans and nature

Examiner Tips and Tricks

One of the best ways to write a "personal and evaluative engagement" is to spend some time thinking about the question. You could call this planning time. Examiners are looking for an introduction that presents your own personal interpretation of the poem in the question, so you will need some time to think about this.

So, instead of setting straight to writing an introduction that lists all the techniques you are about to analyse, or one that begins with the poet's biography, carefully consider how you would answer the specific question you have been asked, and write this in your introduction.

Individual identity

- Charles Mungoshi was born in Zimbabwe in 1947 and grew up on a farm
- He worked for the Forestry Commission before he began writing:
  - The poem 'Before the Sun' is semi-autobiographical in nature
  - It depicts a young boy cutting wood with familiarity and expertise, in a hot, rural landscape
- Mungoshi's poetry often covers themes about identity and masculinity:

- At the same time, the teenage boy is innocent, playing games with the sun and describing it as a "grown-up"

Humans and nature

- Having grown up in Zimbabwe, Charles Mungoshi writes about the familiar landscape of Southern Africa
- In 'Before the Sun', Mungoshi describes the heat of the day to come, the "intense blue" and "heavy" rain, alluding to the close connection between the weather and those living in sub-tropical region
- The boy eats "maize" and shares it with the sun, conveying his deep respect and close connection with nature:
  - He refers to "prayer" and "sacrificial" rituals, suggesting worship of the sun
- The final line, describing two "skeletons" in the sun, may warn against a threat to nature, which presents a traditional, simple life alongside a twentieth century concern
- Mungoshi's poem uses a style similar to a Japanese poetic style in its short, simple descriptions, such as in "bright chips" and "sharp axe", and occasional haiku:
  - This allows him to show the starkness and simplicity of nature, as well as its power to create a deep experience

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed guides on Paper 1 Section A: what the question is asking and how to get full marks. You will also find an example of a full, annotated model answer.

It is important to remember that no marks are given for comments on any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem given.

Sources

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Charles Mungoshi - Zimbabwe." Poetry International, https://www.poetryinternational.com/en/poets-poems/poets/poet/102-5752_Mungoshi. Accessed 24 August 2025.

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